# Robinson Crusoe

## A simplified retelling

Original story by Daniel Defoe

The same journey. Clearer, shorter English.

Abridged and retold for Speak Boldly Intermediate reading practice


© 2026 Founded by Mira Nasser Louis.

# 1. Going to sea

My father wanted me to remain at home and build a secure life. I wanted to go to sea. In 1651, I left England without his approval.

My first voyages brought storms, fear and opportunities to turn back. Instead, I continued. On one voyage, pirates captured our ship, and I was enslaved in North Africa.

After a long period, I escaped in a boat with a boy called Xury. We travelled along the coast until a Portuguese captain took us aboard. He helped me reach Brazil.

There, I became a plantation owner. Although I knew the suffering of captivity, I became involved in an economy that depended on slavery. I eventually joined a voyage intended to obtain enslaved people from Africa for plantation labour.

That voyage ended in disaster. A storm drove our ship towards an island. Our boat overturned, and I was thrown ashore. When I could finally look around, no other survivor was with me.


© 2026 Founded by Mira Nasser Louis.

# 2. What the wreck could provide

I had escaped the sea, but I had almost nothing. Fear kept me awake. I did not know whether the island held dangerous animals or whether I would ever see another person.

The ship remained on a sandbank within reach. Over several journeys, I carried tools, food, weapons, clothing and other useful things ashore on makeshift rafts. Each object changed what I might be able to do.

I built a shelter near a rock face and surrounded it with a protective fence. I made a place for stores and began keeping a calendar by marking a post. Recording the days helped me feel that time was not simply disappearing.

I kept a journal too. Setting down my difficulties helped me separate immediate tasks from fears I could not solve. I needed food, water and shelter before I could answer what the rest of my life might become.


© 2026 Founded by Mira Nasser Louis.

# 3. Learning by failing

At first, I depended on what I had brought from the ship. Slowly, I learned to provide more for myself. I hunted, dried grapes and planted grain that had unexpectedly sprouted near my shelter.

Harvesting was only one part of making bread. I needed to store the grain, grind it and find a way to bake it. Tasks that had once seemed simple now required many smaller discoveries.

I made rough pots and eventually learned how to harden them with fire. I caught goats and began keeping them so that I would have a steadier supply of milk and meat.

Some ambitious plans failed. I made a large canoe, then discovered that I could not move it to the water. Months of work could not change the fact that I had ignored an essential practical question.

Illness frightened me more than hard work. Alone, I had nobody to bring water or notice whether I was recovering. Survival depended on patience, habits and luck as well as determination.


© 2026 Founded by Mira Nasser Louis.

# 4. A footprint

Years passed. I explored more of the island and created a second shelter in a pleasant inland place. I had food and useful routines, but no human conversation.

Then I found a footprint in the sand.

Instead of joy, I felt terror. Someone else had been there. I imagined danger everywhere and strengthened my defences. Even a single mark could overturn the sense of security I had built over years.

Later, I discovered evidence that visitors sometimes came to the island and killed captives there. I watched from concealment and struggled with fear and questions about whether to intervene.

When one captive escaped and ran towards me, I helped him. The men pursuing him were killed. I called the rescued man Friday, after the day on which we met, rather than learning and using his original name.

My way of telling the story reflected the unequal power I assumed between us. Yet I could not survive this new life without his knowledge and help.


© 2026 Founded by Mira Nasser Louis.

# 5. Friday

Friday learned English, and we gradually found ways to understand one another. He helped with work, described places beyond the island and asked questions that challenged things I had taken for granted.

For the first time in many years, I had someone to speak with. Our days were no longer filled only with my own thoughts.

We built a boat with the possibility of leaving. Before we could use it as planned, more visitors arrived with captives. Friday and I intervened and rescued two men: a Spaniard and Friday’s father.

The Spaniard knew other shipwrecked Europeans living elsewhere. We discussed bringing them to the island so that we could prepare a larger escape together. Before attempting it, we needed enough food to support more people.

The Spaniard and Friday’s father went to make arrangements. While they were away, an English ship appeared offshore. It looked like the rescue I had imagined for years, but approaching it was not simple.


© 2026 Founded by Mira Nasser Louis.

# 6. An English captain

Men from the ship brought prisoners ashore. They were mutineers, and one of their captives was the captain. I watched before revealing myself.

The captain agreed to take me home if I helped him recover his vessel. With Friday beside me, we used our knowledge of the island to confuse the mutineers and separate them into smaller groups.

Eventually, the captain regained control. Some men remained on the island. I left information and supplies that might help those still expected to arrive.

After more than twenty-eight years, I sailed away. The island had become a home, a prison and a place shaped by my labour. Leaving it was a kind of return to life, but it did not erase the years spent there.

In England, I found that my parents were dead. Through the honest Portuguese captain and others, I also learned that my Brazilian property had produced wealth during my absence.


© 2026 Founded by Mira Nasser Louis.

# 7. Beyond the island

I travelled across Europe with Friday, facing further dangers, including an attack by wolves during the journey through the mountains. The world I had wanted to return to was not a place without risk.

Back in England, I arranged my affairs, married and had children. For a time, I lived with the ordinary responsibilities I had once dismissed as uninteresting.

After my wife died, the wish to travel returned. I later visited the island again and found that life there had continued without me.

Looking back, I could describe useful discoveries, frightening mistakes and unlikely escapes. I could also see how dependent I had been on people and resources I had not created. Even my years alone had begun with the labour of others preserved in a wrecked ship.


© 2026 Founded by Mira Nasser Louis.

# Words to keep

Plantation — a large farm growing crops for sale, historically often using enslaved labour. Crusoe owned a plantation in Brazil.

Makeshift — created temporarily from whatever is available. He built a makeshift raft.

Resource — something useful for meeting a need. Tools were essential resources.

Captive — a person held against their will. Friday was escaping from captivity.

Mutineer — a sailor rebelling against the captain. The mutineers took prisoners ashore.

Dependence — the need to rely on someone or something. Crusoe’s survival involved more dependence than he first recognised.


© 2026 Founded by Mira Nasser Louis.

# A question to carry with you

Which parts of survival come from personal effort, and which depend on help, prior knowledge or resources made by others?


© 2026 Founded by Mira Nasser Louis.